



A QUIET Friday night in Delano, Calif. Residents in the 22nd Congressional District say they feel squeezed by housing, gas and grocery prices, and farmers have been hit with high fertilizer costs amid the war with Iran.

GARY KAZANJIAN For The Times

Leaders in the AI industry call for a slowdown

Anthropic, OpenAI and xAI's chiefs cite the technology's mounting risks.

By KEVIN WHITELAW AND SETH FIEGERMAN

Leaders of the world's biggest artificial intelligence platforms said it's time to slow the development pace of their most advanced — and most lucrative — models, citing escalating risks of the technology.

Anthropic Chief Executive Dario Amodei issued a lengthy blog post Saturday saying his company would implement new safety steps such as third-party evaluators while calling on the industry to support a broader downshift.

OpenAI Chief Sam Altman quickly pledged to adopt Amodei's suggestion of "independent evaluators with employee-like access," while Elon Musk, who runs xAI Corp., wrote, "Dario is right."

While all three leaders have over the years warned of the risks of AI, an actual coordinated slowdown has little precedent in a cut-throat industry that has historically cranked out one product after another in the name of boosting user engagement, grabbing market share and striving for sales gains.

But the anxiety about severe AI risks has begun to enter the mainstream, driven in part by last week's high-profile resignation of an Anthropic researcher over existential fears that his

[See AI, A7]

Many want a life in L.A. It comes at a steep cost

The city ranks as one of the most expensive places to live in the country. And prices continue to rise.

L.A.'s overall cost-of-living index ranks ninth

National rank	Category	L.A. index score
9	Overall	150
9	Housing	227
6	Transportation	138
17	Healthcare	119
15	Other goods & services	118
13	Grocery	112
35	Utilities	112

The findings are based on 2026 second-quarter Cost of Living Index, which compares prices in 248 participating urban areas. The index reflects the spending patterns of households in the top 20% of local incomes. The average across participating areas is set at 100.

Council for Community and Economic Research

AVA HU Los Angeles Times

By LAURENCE DARMIENTO, ANNIKA DUNEJA AND AVA HU

Cheryl Palumbo was out shopping for herself and her husband last week to pick up some items she had forgotten the day before at the supermarket — and couldn't quite believe her bill.

The 78-year-old retiree had already spent \$150 and here she was, back at her local Ralphs, forking over another \$70 for fruit, vegetables and other food crammed into three bags.

"My Haagen-Dazs ice cream can go for like \$6.99 a pint, and they had it on sale today for \$3.99. But you finish that in two sittings," said the Chatsworth resident. "I bought a pear the other day — one pear for \$1.91. Everything is just so crazy."

[See Cost, A12]

L.A. sports billionaires chase more assets, titles and clout

As summer peaked, it felt like a good time to be a Southern California sports fan.

The Dodgers had won back-to-back World Series championships. The Lakers had a new billionaire owner, Mark Walter, who promised to usher in a new era. The Stan Kroenke-owned Rams were seen as Super Bowl LIX contenders. And the long-suffering Clippers had Steve Ballmer, the former Microsoft titan who built a new state-of-the-art arena and promised to take the team to

Two weeks of upheaval for local franchises illustrate the stakes beyond the final scores

By Hannah Fry

the next level.

Then, in the course of two weeks, everything got turned upside down. Walter sold the Lakers but has vowed to keep the Dodgers. Kroenke bought the Angels. Ballmer was suspended after the NBA found he circumvented the league's salary cap.

The whole series of events underscores how professional sports has become the domain of a billionaire class for whom the competition is about more than what

[See L.A. sports, A10]

California lake in crisis gets tribal guardians

By NOAH HAGGERTY

Jose "Moke" Simon III recalls as a child in the '70s watching the creeks that flow into Clear Lake in Northern California turn black with fish — a fish found only in these waters — as they made their springtime run.

Someone would call from the neighboring reservation with the news: "The hitch is running!" Everybody would grab their ice chests and pile into cars.

"They ran so thick in the rivers, you didn't even need a pole," said Simon, now chair



JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

SEVEN tribes around Clear Lake have signed an agreement with government officials to co-manage it.

of the Middletown Rancheria of Pomo Indians. "You'd just get in there and splash them out of the river, or catch them in your shirt."

But those days are gone. As Clear Lake, which sits in Lake County, north of Napa, faces mercury contamination, toxic algal blooms and predatory invasive fish, the Clear Lake hitch — known by local tribes as the chi — are in serious trouble. Another fish unique to the watershed, the Clear Lake splittail, is already extinct.

After years of advocacy and on-the-ground work to save the fish, the seven

[See Lake, A10]

Central Valley district tests the economy's stress on voters

In a rural area crucial to House control, few are committed. Many are disillusioned.

By JUSTINE MCDANIEL

DELANO, Calif. — The rows of candies and nuts at the Guadalajara Meat Market — tamarindo con chile, seasoned pistachios, spicy paletas — sat mostly untouched as customers filtered through this carniceria in the late afternoon heat.

"You see a lot of people consuming the minimum, what they need to get by through the week," said owner Carina Murillo, 31, as she checked out customers on a recent weekday. "Instead of buying six items, they're buying three items."

While customers bypass extras, like the snacks at the front counter, Murillo's costs have gone up. Imported goods from Mexico and Canada have become more difficult to source and some-

times carry tariffs, she said. Transportation fees have risen as diesel prices respond to the war in Iran. The market's insurance costs have risen by about a third. All of it has forced Murillo to increase prices.

As the area struggles, Murillo, a college graduate who years ago felt motivated enough to door-knock for political causes, is among those who have become disillusioned. Those in Washington, she said, don't understand the lives of the working people who keep the country running.

There have been "years where I feel completely overpowered to the point where I'm not motivated to take part," said Murillo, who didn't vote in 2024 but plans to do so in November. "That's what happens when you feel discouraged or like nothing's going to change."

The economic strife plaguing Americans is clear in this rural, majority-Latino Central Valley congressional district, home to the

[See Economy, A8]

Pratt voters may be key to mayor's race

Challenge for Raman and Bass is to court his supporters without alienating liberal base.

By NOAH GOLDBERG

More than 300,000 Los Angeles voters who cast ballots for losing candidates in the mayoral primary are up for grabs in the Nov. 3 runoff between Karen Bass and Nithya Raman, and their decisions could determine who will lead the city for the next four years.

The biggest prize within that group is the nearly 218,000 Angelenos who voted for Spencer Pratt, a Republican who fared best in his home base of Pacific Palisades and the city's more conservative neighborhoods — and who has con-

tinued to hurl jabs at both Bass and Raman from the sidelines.

"The Pratt vote is of critical importance," said Dan Schnur, a former Republican political consultant who now is a professor of political communications at USC, UC Berkeley and Pepperdine. "It might not have been enough votes for him to make it to the runoff, but in a close election his supporters could be determinative."

Bass and Raman — both Democrats — must make inroads with Pratt voters without putting off their base of liberals and progressives who are expected to be out in force for the midterm elections, Schnur and other analysts say.

"You don't want to have a message to Pratt voters where you might gain one

[See Voters, A9]



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

LUCAS MUSEUM

Some insider history, plus what to see and expect as the museum dedicated to narrative art nears its launch. ENTERTAINMENT, E1-8

Saudi Arabia has few options

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Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 85/67. B8

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The plan to kill rules on plastics

Industry campaign sought to dismantle landmark recycling laws. CALIFORNIA, B1

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